GLADIATOR TACTICS

GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT (UPDATED)

Format: Turn-based Tactics (3x3 on 8x8 map / 4v4 on 10x10 map)

1. Global Rules & Core Mechanics

Turn Structure & Phases

- **Phases:** Each turn consists of 2 phases: Move → Attack.
- **Skill Economy:** Using any active skill immediately ends the Attack phase (no basic attack after a skill, unless specified).

Damage & Armor System

- **Armor:** Acts as a secondary HP bar (a damage-absorbing shield). Depleted before HP takes damage.
- **Multi-hit Resolution:** Each hit in a multi-hit skill (e.g., Flurry) is resolved separately for the purposes of dodge, crit, and on-hit effects. Armor is stripped per hit.

Status Effects

- **Root:** Sets Movement to 0. Prevents ALL forms of movement, including basic moves and movement granted by skills (e.g., Charge, Flurry, Hit & Run, Ironclad Advance).
- **Disarm:** Prevents basic attacks and any skill whose primary effect is dealing damage. Does not prevent utility skills (buffs, movement, taunts).
- **Stun:** Prevents all actions (Move and Attack) for the duration.
- **Slow:** Reduces the Movement attribute of the unit by 1 (minimum Move cannot drop below 0). Does not block movement skills unless specified.

2. Class Matrix Overview

Class	Move	Atk Shape	Init	HP	Armor	ATK	Role / Archetype
Dimachaerus	3	Cross 1	15	25	10	12	Glass Cannon / Armor Shredder
Sagittarius	2	Diamond 3 (Excl. Cross 1)	14	25	10	12	Zone Control / Overwatch
Retiarius	3	Diamond 2 (Excl. Cross 1)	13	25	15	11	Kite / Hard CC (Root)
Thraex	2	Cross 1	10	30	20	16	Bruiser / Burst Armor Bypass
Laquearius	3	Cross 2	9	25	20	11	Repositioning / Pull
Secutor	2	Square 1	8	30	20	12	Sticky Bruiser / Anti-Kite
Hoplomachus	2	Cross 2	7	30	20	13	Ranged Poke / Shape-shifter
Scissor	2	Cross 1	6	25	25	13	Utility / Disarm
Velites	2	Cross 3 (Excl. Cross 1)	5	25	15	15	Skirmisher / Javelin Thrower
Provocator	2	Square 1	4	30	30	10	Tank / Force Engagement
Murmillo	2	Square 1	3	30	30	12	Heavy CC / Wall Synergy
Crupellarius	1	Square 1	2	35	35	12	Juggernaut / Immovable

3. Detailed Class Kits & Breakdown

Dimachaerus

Skill: Flurry (CD: 3)

Range: Cross 1 (Adjacent)

Description: Unleashes a rapid flurry of 3 strikes on an adjacent target. Each strike deals 0.7x ATK physical damage. Using this skill immediately ends the Attack phase.

> ***Dev Note (Multi-hit Logic):*** *The Dimachaerus does not move when using this skill in the base kit. Total damage is 2.1x ATK. Each of the 3 hits is resolved separately for the purposes of dodge, crit, and on-hit effects. Armor is stripped by 0.7x per hit.*

Sagittarius

Skill: Overwatch (CD: 2)

Description: Enters a stance. Automatically attacks the first enemy that enters their attack zone (Diamond 3, Excl. Cross 1) during an enemy's turn. Deals 1.0x ATK physical damage.

> ***Dev Note:*** *Triggers strictly on enemy movement into the attack zone.*

Retiarius

Skill: Net (CD: 3)

Range: Diamond 2 (Excluding adjacent Cross 1 tiles)

Description: Throws a net targeting 1 enemy within Diamond 2 range. Deals 0.5x ATK physical damage and Roots the target (Movement = 0) for 1 turn. Using this skill immediately ends the Attack phase.

> ***Dev Note (Critical Edge Case):*** *Cannot target adjacent Cross 1 tiles. This is a deliberate design choice to force the Retiarius to maintain optimal kiting distance (exactly 2 tiles away). It prevents the player from safely Rooting an adjacent enemy with zero risk of melee retaliation. Root blocks ALL forms of movement, including skill-based dashes.*

Thraex

Skill: Sica Cut (CD: 2)

Range: Cross 1 (Adjacent)

Description: Strikes an adjacent enemy (Cross 1 shape) with a curved blade, dealing 1.2x ATK physical damage. 15% of this damage bypasses Armor and directly reduces HP. Using this skill immediately ends the Attack phase.

> ***Dev Note:*** *Replaces the old passive Armor Piercer. The armor bypass applies only to this specific skill, not to basic attacks. This limits the Thraex's anti-armor capabilities to a tactical window, preventing them from passively melting tanks with basic attacks.*

Laquearius

Skill: Hook (CD: 3)

Range: Cross 2

Description: Throws a lasso targeting 1 enemy within Cross 2 range. Deals 0.5x ATK physical damage and pulls the target to an adjacent tile directly next to the Laquearius.

> ***Dev Note (Edge Case):*** *Pull fails if the destination tile is occupied or blocked by terrain.*

Secutor

Skill: Hamstring (CD: 3)

Range: Square 1

Description: Attacks an enemy within Square 1 range. Deals 1.0x ATK physical damage and applies Slow (-1 Move) for 1 turn. This action immediately ends the Attack phase.

> ***Dev Note:*** *Lacking immediate gap-closers in the base kit, landing Hamstring is critical to preventing high-mobility targets (like Retiarius or Dimachaerus) from kiting.*

Hoplomachus

Skill: Spear Throw (CD: 2)

Description: Throws a spear (Cross 3 shape) dealing 1.2x ATK physical damage. For the next 2 turns, the Hoplomachus's basic attack shape changes to Square.

> ***Dev Note:*** *Shape change lasts 2 turns (including the current turn).*

Scissor

Skill: Disarm (CD: 3)

Description: Deals 1.0x ATK physical damage. The target is Disarmed and cannot attack for 1 turn (but can still move and defend).

> ***Dev Note:*** *Disarm blocks basic attacks and damage-skills, but not utility skills (like buffs or movement).*

Velites

Skill: Pinning Javelin (CD: 3)

Range: Cross 3 (Excluding adjacent Cross 1 tiles)

Description: Throws a javelin in a straight line at an enemy, dealing 1.0x ATK physical damage and applying Slow (-1 Movement) for 1 turn. Using this skill immediately ends the Attack phase.

> ***Dev Note:*** *Replaces the old Armor-Piercing Javelin. This version does not bypass Armor. Because the range is Cross 3, the Velites must be aligned in a straight cardinal line (up, down, left, or right) with the target, encouraging tactical positioning behind frontline allies. Slow does not stack and cannot reduce Movement below 1. This allows the Velites to kite melee threats and set up kills for allies without stealing the Retiarius's hard-CC (Root) role.*

Provocator

Skill: Taunt (CD: 2)

Description: Selects 1 target within Diamond 3 range (Including adjacent Cross 1 melee tiles). Forces the target to move into melee range and attack the Provocator.

> ***Dev Note (Edge Case Handled):*** *If the target cannot reach the Provocator (due to Root, Stun, Slow, or blocked pathing), the movement fails or cuts short on the last accessible tile. However, the target still attacks from their current tile if in range. If out of range, the target skips the attack.*

Murmillo

Skill: Shield Bash (CD: 2)

Range: Cross 1 (Adjacent)

Description: Deals 0.8x ATK physical damage and knocks the target back 1 tile. Using this skill immediately ends the Attack phase.

> ***Dev Note (Collision & Difficulty):*** *While the Murmillo's basic attack shape remains Square (allowing them to hit diagonally with standard attacks), the Shield Bash skill is restricted to Cross 1 range to simplify collision resolution vectors and avoid complex diagonal knockbacks. The player must align strictly in a cardinal direction (up, down, left, right) to execute the bash.*

Crupellarius

Skill: Ironclad Advance (CD: 2)

Description: Move up to 2 tiles and gain +15 Armor until the start of your next turn. This action immediately ends the Attack phase.

Passive: Immune to all forced movement (knockbacks, pull, dashes).

Appendix A: Future Meta-Progression & Upgrades (Backlog Notes)

The following upgrades are temporary notes for future expansion and do not apply to the balanced Base Kits.

Secutor Upgrade Path Ideas:

- **Upgrade 1 (Relentless Pursuit):** Grants Passive. If hit by an attack from 2+ tiles away, step 1 tile toward the attacker. (Triggers once per enemy turn. Suppressed by Root).
- **Upgrade 2 (Crippling Strike):** Enhances Hamstring. The Slow effect now also reduces the target's Initiative by -2 for the duration.

Provocator Upgrade Path Ideas:

- **Upgrade 1 (Unshakable Guard):** When using Taunt, the Provocator gains a buff reducing incoming damage by 50% for 1 turn. This buff is gained regardless of the target's action outcome.

Murmillo Upgrade Path Ideas:

- **Upgrade 1 (Concussive Blow):** Enhances Shield Bash. If the target collides with a wall or another unit, they suffer an additional 0.7x ATK physical damage and are Stunned for 1 turn.

Crupellarius Upgrade Path Ideas:

- **Tier 1 Upgrade (Oiled Joints):** The Crupellarius becomes immune to the Slow status effect.
- **Tier 2 Upgrade (Spiked Armor):** When hit by an enemy basic attack, the Crupellarius retaliates for 0.5x ATK physical damage. This can trigger 1 time per round.
- **Tier 3 Upgrade (Ultimate):** Upgrades Spiked Armor. The counter-attack can now trigger 2 times per round, OR the counter-attack damage increases to 1.0x ATK (player's choice).

Dimachaerus Upgrade Path Ideas:

- **Acrobatic Assault:** Upgrades Flurry. The Dimachaerus now leaps in a straight line up to Cross 2 to reach the target before striking. Damage per hit increases to 0.8x ATK (2.4x total).